



The facade of the temple of Ramesses II at Abu Simbel features four colossal seated statues of the pharaoh, but the statue second from left has crumbled.

TOWARD THE END OF THE 2ND MILLENNIUM BCE,

the eastern Mediterranean and Western Asia were a **mosaic of empires**, which comprised Egypt, Babylonia, Elam, Assyria, and the Hittites in Anatolia. Borders fluctuated as each kingdom strove to gain ascendancy over its neighbors through conquest or diplomacy. In war and peace, **vital trade routes**, through which tin and copper for **bronze** reached the region, remained intact.

A frequent flashpoint for conflict was the **Levant** (modern Syria and Lebanon), which Egypt had lost to the Hittites following the reign of Akhenaten (see 1350 BCE). In the 13th century BCE, Pharaoh Seti I and his son **Ramesses II** campaigned to win it back. Ramesses' 67-year reign (r. 1279–1213 BCE) was

“YOU ARE A **GREAT WARRIOR** WITHOUT EQUAL, **VICTORIOUS** IN SIGHT OF THE WHOLE WORLD.”

Inscription commemorating the victory of Ramesses II at Qadesh

a time of **stability and prosperity** for Egypt. Through a combination of war, diplomacy, and strategic marriage, Ramesses sought to extend Egyptian influence to Western Asia. In the 1270s BCE, he fought a series of wars with the Hittite king, Muwattalis II, of which

Ancient propaganda

A detail from the temple of Ramesses II at Abu Simbel shows the king firing an arrow, taking on the Hittite army single-handed at the Battle of Qadesh.



the most famous was the **Battle of Qadesh** (c. 1274 BCE). Although Ramesses claimed victory at Qadesh, the battle is believed to have been inconclusive, and the Hittites held on to the region.

In 1259 BCE, after further campaigns in Syria, Ramesses tried a different tactic, and negotiated a **pioneering peace treaty** with the new Hittite king, **Hattusilis III**. Ramesses also took two Hittite princesses in marriage (he had about seven wives in total). Following the treaty, Ramesses kept up a friendly correspondence with the Hittite ruler, which was recorded on clay tablets in Akkadian cuneiform script.

Ramesses also embarked on an extensive program of **monument-building**. On Egypt's southern border with Nubia, he constructed the magnificent temple of **Abu Simbel**. He founded a new capital at **Per-Ramesses** in Lower Egypt, although Thebes in Upper Egypt remained an important center. West of Thebes he built a vast mortuary temple, which doubled as a palace, court, and center of learning.

The late 2nd millennium BCE saw the resurgence of Ashur, in what is now called the **Middle Assyrian Empire** (1350–1000 BCE). Following the death of Shamshi-Adad in 1781 BCE (see 1850 BCE), Ashur had become a vassal first of Babylon, then of Mitanni. A revival of Ashur's fortunes began under **Ashur-uballit I** (r. 1363–1328 BCE), who broke free of Mitannian rule and carved out a kingdom in northern Iraq. His later successors, Shalmaneser I and Tukulti-Ninurta I, continued to gain territory, expanding the kingdom's borders west to conquer eastern Mitanni and briefly, from 1225–1216 BCE, southeast to Babylonia.

In the Aegean, the **Mycenaean** palace-kings of the Greek mainland **continued to thrive**.



The boulders used to make these walls, now in ruins, at Mycenae on the Greek mainland were so huge, later civilizations believed they were built by giants.

BETWEEN 1250 AND ABOUT 1050 BCE,

many of the **powers** that had dominated Western Asia for centuries **went into decline**, and some disappeared altogether. The eastern Mediterranean entered a **time of turmoil**, and many coastal cities were laid waste by unknown invaders—written records of the period give few clues as to their identity. First to succumb were the Hittites, whose capital **Hattusas** was **sacked** and abandoned c. 1200 BCE. By c. 1180 BCE, Hittite possessions in the Levant were lost and the **empire fragmented**.

These conflicts were most likely instigated by the waves of migrants known collectively as the **Sea Peoples**. These warlike peoples came from many different areas, including Sicily, Sardinia, Greece, Libya, and Anatolia. Whatever their origins, their movements through the eastern Mediterranean in c. 1200–1100 BCE led to attacks on Cyprus, Egypt, Anatolia, and Canaan and Syria in the Levant. In 1178 BCE, the Egyptian pharaoh **Ramesses III** drove the Sea Peoples from Lower Egypt, but

could not prevent them from colonizing the Levant.

Around 1200 BCE, the **Mycenaean kingdoms** entered a time of upheaval, a result of both internal disintegration and external threats. The defenses of many Mycenaean palaces were strengthened. Records at Pylos show the inhabitants feared attack from the sea. By 1100 BCE, most of the Mycenaean palaces had been sacked and abandoned. This triggered the so-called **Dark Age of Greece**, when writing fell out of use, not to be reintroduced until the Homeric age (see 800 BCE).

In the late Bronze Age, parts of Europe came to be dominated by the **Urnfield Culture**—named after the practice of cremating the dead and burying the remains in funerary urns, sometimes accompanied by rich grave goods. This culture originated in the **Danube region** in 1300 BCE, and spread to Italy and central and eastern Europe in the following centuries.

Between 1200 and 700 BCE **iron technology** spread northward from Greece to Central Europe.

“THEY CAME **BOLDLY** **SAILING** IN THEIR WARSHIPS FROM THE **MIDST OF THE SEA**, NONE BEING ABLE TO WITHSTAND THEM...”

An inscription by **Ramesses II** (r. 1279–1213), referring to the Sea Peoples

